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Swiatek Social Coping Strategies in Gifted Students

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Introduction/Background

Gifted students often feel a real tradeoff between showing their ability and fitting in with peers. This social pressure is the background for Mary Swiatek's work on coping strategies such as denial, hiding, and conformity. (3 sources)

Research on gifted students has long described a social problem at school: students may feel they have to choose between being known as highly able and being accepted by peers. One study summarized this as a choice between embracing intellectual ability and enjoying social popularity. (Phelps et al., 2021) This helps explain why social coping became an important topic in the gifted education literature.

Later work shows that many gifted students are very aware of what Carter et al. call the "SGP," and they often try to manage how much others know about their ability so they can have more typical peer interactions. (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019) Cross-cultural interview evidence also suggests that this is not just a local issue. Across several countries, gifted students reported feeling visible because of their high ability, facing high expectations and pressure, and worrying about jealousy, rejection, and how their success affects peers. In response, many tried to hide their abilities or conform to peer behavior. (Cross et al., 2019)

Taken together, this background sets up Swiatek's focus on social coping strategies: gifted students are not only dealing with achievement demands, but also with the everyday need to protect belonging, avoid stigma, and manage peer reactions in school settings. (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019)

Evidence

(Phelps et al., 2021)

Covert Aggression and Gifted Adolescent Girls

> *"Wood and Craigen (2011) found gifted students faced a choice between embracing their intellectual ability and enjoying social popularity among their peers."*

(Carter et al., 2025)

School Experiences of Gifted Adolescents and Their Peers

> *"Multiple studies have shown that gifted students are aware of the SGP and frequently manage the information others have about them to achieve more typical social interactions within the school environment (Coleman et al., 2014); J. R. (Cross et al., 2019)T. L. Cross et al. 1995;T. L. Cross and Stewart 1995)."*

(Cross et al., 2019)

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."

Swiatek's Social Coping Framework

Swiatek's framework gives a way to organize how gifted students manage peer life. It centers on a small set of recurring strategies, especially denial of giftedness, conformity for popularity, peer-focused behavior, humor, and staying socially active. (2 sources)

Swiatek's contribution was to turn the broad idea of "social coping" into a more defined framework tied to gifted students' day-to-day school experiences. She developed the Social Coping Questionnaire in 1995 to measure the specific beliefs and behaviors gifted students use when dealing with the social side of high ability. In its original form, analyses identified four main coping dimensions: Denial of Giftedness, Popularity/Conformity, Peer Acceptance, and Activity Level. Later results expanded this into five factors that explained 42.0% of the variance: Denying Giftedness, Social Interaction, Humor, Focus on Popularity/Conformity, and Peer Acceptance. (KONIK, 2023)

This framework is useful because it shows that coping is not just one behavior, like hiding ability. Instead, it includes a wider set of strategies that are fairly specific to giftedness: denying giftedness, reducing its impact on peer acceptance, hiding giftedness or conforming to peer behavior, denying the importance of popularity, using humor, helping others, and staying busy through social interaction and high activity levels. In other words, Swiatek's model treats social coping as a pattern of ways gifted students can manage stigma, belonging, and visibility among peers, rather than as a single response. (Tourreix et al., 2023) (KONIK, 2023)

Evidence

(KONIK, 2023)

Turkish adaptation of Social Coping Questionnaire for gifted students

"Swiatek developed the Social Coping Questionnaire in 1995 to evaluate the particular coping mechanisms employed by gifted students.In its original form, the SCQ (Swiatek, 1995) had 35 questions "that address beliefs and activities relating to various social aspects of intellectual giftedness."A component analysis of the scores revealed four social coping mechanisms: Denial of Giftedness, Popularity/Conformity, Peer Acceptance, and Activity Level"

"Results yielded five factors that accounted for 42.0% of the variance: Denying Giftedness, Social Interaction, Humor, Focus on Popularity/Conformity, and Peer Acceptance."

(Tourreix et al., 2023)

Non-Cognitive Specificities of Intellectually Gifted Children and Adolescents: A Systematic Review of the Literature

"There appear to be coping strategies that are specific to giftedness (Swiatek, 1995)(Swiatek, 2001), such as denying giftedness; reducing the impact of giftedness on peer acceptance; hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors; denying importance of popularity; using humor; helping others; and engaging in social interactions and a high activity level to keep busy and share common interests."

Denial, Hiding, and Minimizing Giftedness

A core part of Swiatek's social coping picture is that some gifted students try to make their ability less visible. They may deny being gifted, hide achievement, or build other identities that feel safer with peers. (3 sources)

- **Denial of giftedness**: Some gifted students cope by directly downplaying or denying that they are gifted, especially when being seen as highly able may bring unwanted peer attention or social cost. (Peairs et al., 2011)

- **Hiding ability from peers**: A related strategy is to keep giftedness less visible in everyday school life. This can mean masking achievement or avoiding standing out so that interactions with classmates feel more normal. (Peairs et al., 2011) (Kennedy et al., 2018)
- **Minimizing differences**: Rather than only hiding labels, some students try to reduce any signs that make them seem different from average peers. In work on Chinese gifted learners, this included coping aimed at minimizing differences and making social interaction easier. (Fong et al., 2014)
- **Avoid, hide, or minimize achievement**: The pressure is not only about the word "gifted." Students may also try to soften how much others notice their performance or achievement levels for social reasons. (Kennedy et al., 2018)
- **Alternative identities**: Some adolescents do more than hide ability; they develop other identities that seem more acceptable in peer groups shaped by conformity. This helps explain why denial can be active identity management, not just silence. (Peairs et al., 2011)
- **Part of a broader coping set**: Denial and hiding often appear alongside other strategies such as avoidance, helping others, involvement in activities, and discounting popularity, suggesting that minimizing giftedness is usually one part of a larger social adjustment pattern rather than a single isolated act. (Fong et al., 2014) (Peairs et al., 2011)

Paper	Focus Area	Population Studied	Key Findings	Coping Strategies Analyzed	Comparison To Nongifted Peers	Psychological And Social Challenges
Academic Giftedness and Alcohol Use in Early Adolescence	Alcohol use among gifted adolescents.	Seventh grade students, 42.5% identified as gifted.	Gifted students use alcohol similarly to peers, with giftedness moderating negative adjustment risks.	Experimenting with alcohol to compensate for social price of talents.	Gifted students tried alcohol at similar rates as nongifted students.	Gifted youth may use alcohol to compensate for social challenges related to their academic talents.
Counseling Gifted Students: School-Based Considerations and Strategies	Developmental, emotional, and social challenges of gifted youth	Heterogeneous group, all cultures, backgrounds, interests, achievements.	Gifted students face developmental, emotional challenges; counseling strategies suggested.	Suggestions for school-based counseling strategies.	May not display more psychological, social, or developmental challenges.	Developmental, emotional, and social challenges faced by gifted youth.

Evidence

(Peairs et al., 2011)

Academic Giftedness and Alcohol Use in Early Adolescence

> *"To resolve this conflict, gifted adolescents may mask their giftedness and/or develop alternative identities which are perceived as more socially acceptable and valued within a peer culture motivated by conformity. In fact, researchers have identified that gifted*

adolescents often engage in various social coping strategies to minimize the visibility of their giftedness, including denial of their giftedness, minimizing the visibility of giftedness, increased involvement in socially acceptable compensatory activities, and denying concern about possible social rejection (see, e.g., (Cross et al., 1991)Swiatek, 1995)."

(Kennedy et al., 2018)

Counseling Gifted Students: School-Based Considerations and Strategies

"Gifted students may be more socially mature than their peers, which might similarly inhibit social relationships or lead students to deny or hide giftedness or achievement levels for social reasons (Reis et al., 2004)"

". Giftedness is no exception to this list, and some gifted students may seek to avoid, hide, or minimize their abilities in order to be more like their peers (Cross & Cross, 2015)."

(Fong et al., 2014)

Perfectionism and Chinese Gifted Learners

"Guided by previous investigations on the social coping strategies adopted by Western gifted learners (Colangelo et al., 1983)(Gross, 1989)Pfeiffer & Stocking, 2000;Piechowski, 1997;Swaitek, 1995), Chan (2003a(Chan, 2004)(Chan, 2005) found that Chinese gifted learners generally use coping strategies to minimize their differences with average peers and to facilitate social interaction with peers. To these ends, coping strategies that Chinese gifted learners typically apply include denying and hiding their giftedness, discounting popularity, attempting avoidance, seeking conformity, helping others, and involvement in activities."

Popularity, Conformity, and Peer Acceptance Pressures

Swiatek's popularity/conformity factor points to a basic peer problem: gifted students may feel that showing ability can lower social acceptance. In response, some try to fit peer norms, and this pressure can be especially strong for students who already feel different or who are more visibly gifted. (3 sources)

A key part of Swiatek's framework is that social coping is not only about hiding giftedness; it is also about managing the peer costs of standing out. Studies tied to this line of work suggest that gifted adolescents can feel less popular and have more peer-relation problems than average students, and that highly gifted youth may be at greater risk than modestly gifted youth in ratings tied to popularity and social standing. This helps explain why conformity becomes attractive as a coping strategy: fitting in can feel safer than being openly identified with high ability. (Yun et al., 2011)

This pressure often shows up as a push to match peer expectations. Reviews of gifted students' adjustment note that some students hide their talents in order to be accepted, and that this conformity pressure can come with costs such as frustration, anxiety, depression, and even resistance to authority. In other words, popularity and conformity are not shallow concerns; they can shape both behavior and well-being. (Aziz et al., 2021)

Gendered accounts make the same point in a more specific way. Work on gifted girls notes that many feel pressure to conform because giftedness marks them as different from the norm, and many try to minimize those differences so they are not set apart from friends and same-age peers. This kind of social adaptation can protect belonging in the short term, but it can also become a barrier to full achievement when students learn to accommodate peer norms rather than express their abilities freely. (Gaerlan-Price, 2015)

Taken together, these findings help clarify what Swiatek's popularity/conformity and peer-acceptance factors are getting at. Gifted students are often not simply choosing whether to achieve; they are managing a social tradeoff in which visibility, likability, and belonging can seem to depend on acting less different than they really are. (Yun et al., 2011) (Aziz et al., 2021) (Gaerlan-Price, 2015)

Evidence

(Yun et al., 2011)

Mathematically Gifted Adolescents Have Deficiencies in Social Valuation and Mentalization

"A previous survey-based study supports our hypothesis that gifted adolescents experience difficulties in social coping strategies

(Swiatek, 1995)"

".Specifically, a study using questionnaires found that highly gifted adolescents perceive themselves as less popular, having a greater internal locus of control, and having more social and emotional problems than average adolescents (Brody et al., 1986). In ratings of peer perceptions of athleticism, popularity and social standing, modestly gifted adolescents exceeded the highly gifted, indicating that giftedness may entail risks of developing problems in peer relations (Dauber et al., 1990)."

(Aziz et al., 2021)

Exploration of Challenges Among Gifted and Talented Children

"Some of them might faces conformity pressures. They might hide their talents in order to be accepted and conform to the peer expectation resulted on developing frustrations, anxiety and depression and resistance to authority (Wright-Scott, 2018)."

(Gaerlan-Price, 2015)

Meet, prey, like: A study of gifted girls' interactions with social media

"According to Reis (2002b), many gifted and talented girls feel the pressure to conform because being gifted is seen as being different to the norm.

Gifted girls do not want to be considered different from their friends and same-age peers. Indeed, a tendency exists for many females, regardless of age, to try to minimize their differences. For many gifted girls, however, the problem becomes more difficult as…their talents and gifts set them apart from their peers and friends. (p. 7) Kerr (1991) explains that the process of social adaptation to hide gifts and talents, which includes an "accommodating personality" and a "resourceful adaptation to the environment" (p. 140) is a barrier to achievement."

Related Coping Behaviors and Consequences

Beyond denial and conformity, gifted students may cope by withdrawing, seeking attention, pleasing others, or trying to look like everyone else. Some of these responses can turn into more harmful patterns, especially "dumbing down" or underachieving to fit in. (2 sources)

- **Withdrawal or isolation**: One coping response is to pull back from the group when giftedness is not accepted. This can reduce immediate social stress, but it may also limit support and belonging. (Demir et al., 2021)
- **Attention-seeking**: Some students respond in the opposite way and try to gain attention from others. This suggests that social coping is not always about becoming less visible; sometimes it is about managing peer reactions by controlling visibility in a different way. (Demir et al., 2021)
- **People-pleasing and obedience**: Another pattern is trying to please everyone or be especially obedient. This can work as a way to reduce conflict and keep acceptance, even if it means suppressing one's own needs or differences. (Demir et al., 2021)
- **Trying to "look like everyone else"**: Some gifted students cope by making themselves appear more typical. This overlaps with Swiatek's ideas about minimizing difference, but here the emphasis is on broader self-presentation, not just denying giftedness. (Demir et al., 2021)
- **"Dumbing down" to fit in**: A more direct academic version of social coping is lowering visible performance on purpose so as not to stand out. This has been described as a coping strategy used to fit in with peers. (Furner et al., 2011)
- **Underachievement as a harmful coping pattern**: The literature cited by Furner et al. treats underachievement as one of the more damaging coping responses because the student gives up real academic expression for social safety. (Furner et al., 2011)
- **Serious consequences if unsupported**: These coping patterns are not trivial. The same discussion warns that severe forms of social coping can include chronic blending in, underachievement, and in extreme cases even suicidal behavior, which is why guidance and school support matter. (Furner et al., 2011)
- **Practical implication**: Taken together, these behaviors show that social coping can range from everyday

image management to serious self-limiting or harmful responses. In Swiatek's terms, the issue is not just whether gifted students want popularity, but how far they may go to avoid the social costs of being seen as different. (Furner et al., 2011) (Demir et al., 2021)

Evidence

(Demir et al., 2021)

Examining the Relationship between the Sense of Humor and the Social Exclusion Perceived by Gifted and Talented Students

> *"Clark's (2014) argued that gifted and talented children prefer one of three ways to respond to situations where their intellectual giftedness is not accepted and neglected. These ways are listed as isolating themselves from a group, seeking the attention of others, trying to be obedient by pleasing everyone or trying to look like everyone else."*

(Furner et al., 2011)

Counting on Frank : Using bibliotherapy in mathematics teaching to prevent de-geniusing

> *"Dumbing down can actually be thought of as a 'coping' strategy for these students in order to fit in (Cross, 1997)(L., 2021). Cross believes that one of the most detrimental coping mechanisms academically gifted students employ is under-achievement. According to (Cross, 1997) we must provide effective guidance to the gifted students so that they can chart a new course for not lowering their achievement just to fit in, whether with peers, society or competitive occurrences"*

> *".Teachers need to teach their gifted students strategies so that they will not employ these severe patterns of coping behaviours that include trying to blend in with non-gifted students, under-achievement, and even suicidal behaviour (Cross, 1997)."*

Cross-Cultural and Severity Differences

Swiatek's ideas do not seem limited to one country. Similar coping patterns show up across cultures, and the social risk can be stronger for students who are more visibly or extremely gifted. (2 sources)

Cross-cultural work suggests that the basic social problem Swiatek studied travels fairly well across settings: gifted students can feel different from age peers and may respond by trying to reduce that difference in everyday social life. In research on Chinese gifted learners, students were reported to use strategies meant to minimize differences with average peers and make peer interaction easier, including denying or hiding giftedness, discounting popularity, avoidance, conformity, helping others, and involvement in activities. This matters because it shows that denial and conformity are not only Western themes; they also appear in other cultural contexts, even if the exact form may depend on local norms about modesty, group fit, and social harmony. (Fong et al., 2014)

There also seem to be differences by degree of giftedness. Evidence summarized in work on gifted adolescents suggests that highly gifted students can see themselves as less popular and as having more social and emotional problems than average adolescents, and that modestly gifted youth may do better than highly gifted youth on peer-rated popularity and social standing. In practical terms, the more extreme or visible the giftedness, the harder peer adjustment may become, which helps explain why strong coping strategies like hiding, denial, or conformity may be more likely or more necessary for some students than for others. (Yun et al., 2011)

Evidence

(Fong et al., 2014)

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